

Iron *tsuba*
This *tsuba* (metal guard) for a sword is carved and inlaid with a depiction of a samurai under a flowering prunus tree. It dates from the Edo period (1603–1876).

They were protected from the mounted samurai of Takeda Katsuyori by a fence of stakes and by other *ashigaru* armed with long spears. Fired in volleys, the muskets cut down Takeda's horsemen, exposing the Takeda forces to a deadly counterattack.

FOSSILIZED TRADITION

Instead of fading from the limelight with the advent of the gunpowder age, Japanese samurai were preserved and mythified. Toyotomi Hideyoshi, the *daimyo* who rose to dominance in Japan after the death of Nobunaga in 1582, passed decrees restoring the link between samurai status and noble birth. He also gave the samurai a monopoly of bearing arms. Under the Tokugawa shogunate, which pacified Japan in the 17th century, firearms were largely withdrawn from use and as a result the cult of the samurai sword and swordsmanship grew. The *bushido* tradition was codified and glorified as Japan moved into an era of peace. With no enemies to fight, the samurai were elevated to the status of a national treasure, while losing all practical function. The samurai class was finally abolished in 1876 after the Meiji restoration, the Emperor ending their right to be the only armed force in Japan in favour of a modern, Western-style conscripted army. However, the values attributed to the samurai lived on as an essential element in the culture of modern Japan.

> "EVEN IF A MAN HAS NO NATURAL ABILITY HE CAN BE A WARRIOR … GENERALLY SPEAKING, THE WAY OF THE WARRIOR IS RESOLUTE ACCEPTANCE OF DEATH."
>
> **MIYAMOTO MUSASHI,** *GO RIN NO SHO* (THE BOOK OF FIVE RINGS)

Ritual beheading
A detail of samurai beheading a member of an enemy clan from a scroll painting of *The Burning of the Sanjo Palace.*